

Catalogers Group Meeting Nov. 15, 2001

Present: Renée McBride (recorder), Janice Matthiesen, Rebecca Aiken, Caroline Miller, Joan LoPear, Rita Stumps, Angela Riggio, Luiz Mendes, Louise Ratliff, Nancy Norris, Valerie Bross, Jeff Morehead, Beth Feinberg, Elie Chammou, Gia Aivazian, John Riemer, Jean Rashedi.

I. John Riemer reported on the AdCon retreat held a day earlier. The goal was to develop an action plan for realizing a key component of the Library vision statement developed at the December 2000 retreat: "guiding the discovery of and enabling access to print and digital collections." Additional attendees included Sara Layne, Sarah Elman, Janet Carter, and Sharon Farb.

Prior to the retreat, members were polled on 5 questions:

- What resources are currently being made selected for users?
- What access to these resources is currently being provided?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of the current situation?
- What other resources might be made available?
- What are the barriers to making these new resources available?

Retreat attendees reviewed responses, and summarized their essence in greatest weaknesses/strengths.

Weaknesses	Strengths
No one discovery vehicle is comprehensive	Thoughtful selection
User confusion	Provision of speedy access
Lack of streamlined process for managing e-resources & thus providing access	Sheer volume of e-resources
Aren't maximizing limited staff resources	Actual cataloging from UCLA & UCSD
Lack of consistent selection criteria	Having multiplicity of retrieval methods
Segregation of e-resources	Ability to experiment
Not keeping up with maintenance	Segregation of e-resources
Lack synchronicity among discovery vehicles	

Attendees brainstormed principles that ought to be included in the action plan, after expressing admiration for the list on pp. 14-15 of the SOPAG Access Integration Task Force report <http://www.slp.ucop.edu/sopag/TFAIRReport1.pdf>

During small-group discussion, John presented an alternative means of access to e-resources that was favorably received: hyperlinking lists of ERDB subject and material type descriptors, where the links would embed searches directly against the OPAC. The descriptors themselves would need to reside in specially designated and indexed 9XX fields. The 856 field would need to be keyword indexed, something ACC has already requested. All databases and websites now included in ERDB would need to be in Orion2. A collaborative workflow like BibCORC could help us get new e-resource records into the OPAC quickly. By means of a special keyword in OPAC records, it would be possible to provide just the top 100-200 most essential e-resources to novice users who are looking for a place to start; selectors would need to decide which resources those are.

In response to questions in the plenary group about the future role of the ERDB database we have now, John said that it would be needed for data that has no other home, e.g. licensing data and

troubleshooting reports. Not only would it be possible to provide David Yamamoto's public display for executing ERDB searches, it would also be possible to give the (OPAC-based) ERDB results in a similar, customized form. A written version of this proposal appears at the end of these minutes.

The lists generated at the retreat will be circulated for comment. Then either the same attendees or a smaller group will convene to write up the draft action time did not permit on November 14.

II. Reports from the Internet Librarian 2001 Conference, Pasadena, Nov. 4-8.

A. Rita Stumps: attended sessions dealing with training and adult learning; appreciated reinforcement of adult learning principles.

B. Louise Ratliff: high points included Roy Tenant speaking about XML and keynote speakers of the 2nd and 3rd days; noted that many Powerpoint presentations can be found at:
<http://www.infotoday.com/il2001/presentations/default.htm> .

C. Angela Riggio: This was her 3rd Internet Librarian conference and the best so far. Although the conference was not directly related to what we do, it can give us some ideas about what we might expect to be dealing with in the future. Highlights included the cybertours she attended with Luiz Mendes and Caroline Miller, and the Tennant vs. Wiggins debate about digitizing the entire Library of Congress collection (cf. the very similar Wiggins presentation made in March <http://netfact.com/present/rww-cil-digital-lc-mar2001.html> and <http://escholarship.cdlib.org/rtennant/presentations/2001il/lcdebate/> .)

Angela recommends the following sites with which she became familiar at the conference:

- Vivisimo (www.vivisimo.com)--a "meta" search engine
- IxQuick (www.ixquick.com)--also a meta search engine
- iLor (www.ilor.com)--interesting customizable features (powered by Google)
- Invisible Web (www.invisibleweb.com)--a directory of 10,000 databases, archives, and search engines that normal search engines can't get to
- Moreover (www.moreover.com)--includes a news portal, pretty coool

D. Luiz Mendes: inventoried the buzzwords that ran throughout the 3 days of the conference ("invisible Web" catalog, cyber scouts, cyber guides [to a topic], search engines, metasearch and brokering, taxonomies and directories, synonym lists: categories and subcategories, Internet standards, "search rage," usability and searchability [well organized & logical], link checking, web directories, web rings, subject gateways, "Metadata is cataloging for guys"). He attended two cybertours about effective searching of the Web. See the following websites:

- <http://www.onstrat.com/5tricks.html> (5 Xtreme Searching Tricks)
- <http://gwu.edu/~gprince/london.htm> (Finding Electronic Resources)

E. Caroline Miller: attended sessions about XML for libraries, rebuilding a library website for the 21st century, and metadata (from the corporate viewpoint); cybertours also attended by Luiz Mendes and Angela Riggio (all three found these cybertours to be very interesting and informative). Noted that "taxonomy" was a much bandied-about word and asked several people what it means, receiving a variety of answers. Noted that subject headings and controlled vocabularies--concepts that catalogers have dealt with for a very long time--are now a hot topic in the world of e-resources.

F. Valerie Bross: shared some thoughts prompted by Internet Librarian, John's "Access to E-resources through Hyperlinked Descriptor Lists," and a conversation with Luiz Mendes.

Thoughts to share from Internet Librarian
11/15/2001

Meetings like Internet Librarian invite us to take another look at our own situations and how things can be improved. Basically, I have come away from this particular meeting with three things:

- some tools to help with our own workflow
- some web sites that we might want to include, to enhance the catalog (invisible web)
- a question: why are we doing this, creating this group of records and this controlled vocabulary?

Other people will be sharing thoughts in the first two categories; so what I'd like to do now is spend a couple minutes on the last question. Because after this meeting, I am more certain than ever of the importance of our work in providing access to a selection of resources. But I'm less certain that I'm doing it for this catalog--or even for this generation of catalogs.

I really think that these old online catalogs need to develop in a new way, one that allows more integration with research process. Unlike search engines like Google and Yahoo, we are lucky in the sense that we know who our primary clients are and we know why they are coming to us. So, we don't have to strive to be all things to all people, as the search engines do--to sell people things or to entertain them. People come to us for information.

What role should the catalog play in this?

First, the catalog should provide integrated access to more library services.

- For example, on the library home page, there is a button, "ask a librarian." If this were integrated into the catalog, people could ask for help when they get stuck looking for materials.
- Also, when items are missing or at the bindery, our catalog could initiate an ILL session.
- Pathfinders should be more integrated with the catalog. Bibliographers and reference librarians should be able to grab records from the catalog to build their pathfinders, so that if someone finds an item on a pathfinder, it will automatically display local information--call number, status, etc. Also, within a pathfinder the reference librarian should be able to include a "find similar items" & execute a Z39.50 search against the catalog.
- And from within the catalog, when a user executes a browse subject search, buttons by entries should show whether the subject has an associated pathfinder. Also, pathfinders should be able to be associated with specific items, e.g., help pages to using a specific index.
- Extending the pathfinder idea, instructors should be able to use our pathfinder tool to build syllabi (cf., Cal Poly), so that students looking at a syllabus can immediately see the number of copies on reserve or in the collection and the check-out status.
- Bibliographers should be able to grab groups of records to create "de-facto" collections of resources without editing the bib records (cf., Geac Advance)
- Finally, the catalog should support record management through event awareness. We should be able to enter brief records for trial journals, for example, set an end date, and have the system either automatically delete the records or move the group into a module for manual review (suppressing display). Records for leased e-resources should similarly move into a review/renewal area.

Second, the catalog needs to be better-integrated with the outside world.

- (Thanks, Luiz!) If a user wants to search for items on an author in both the catalog and Google, that should be possible. If someone wants to use the controlled vocabulary from our catalog to build a better search, then there should be a "build your search" tool so that by selecting a term, a Google search is constructed that explicitly pulls in all the synonyms. PubMed messages searches using the thesaurus; the catalog should, too.
- When someone finds a record for a journal and wants to search within it, the SFX button next to the record should allow the user to minimize the catalog into a return button & pull up a browser window with the online index (if there is one).
- Talking about SFX, even though SFX is barely in its infancy, we need a next generation SFX. As we archive materials, we should be able to set things so that the SFX machine can sense whether the primary address is usable, and if not, automatically display the archived version.
- Or, users should be able to retrieve from the catalog a group of indexes and "invisible web" databases, tag the records, and execute a search against them from within the catalog.

These are just a few of the ideas generated by this meeting.

G. John found the Nov. 4 pre-conference "Indexing: Open, Closed and for the Web" by Susan Klement to be an outstanding review and update, in 3 hours, of an entire course taught by others in UCLA's library school. Another pre-conference he attended, "Free and Inexpensive Alternatives to Commercial Databases," by Péter Jacsó, made it seem a good idea to combine access to free and licensed e-resources in a single source, so that the Library doesn't pay for what might actually be free.

While he listened to leaders of dot.coms making their presentations, he found it interesting to reflect on the nature of the employment opportunities at those organizations, how they are able to attract and utilize the skills of library school graduates specializing in cataloging, and what we might be able to do to counter those recruitment success to staff our department in the future.

III. Announcements

The next meeting of Catalogers Group, on November 29, starts 30 minutes early: 2:00-3:30. It consists of searching training and will take place in the West Media Classroom. All staff in the Department are requested to attend.

While reading the Task Force on Access Integration report, another idea for improving access to electronic resources came to mind. It falls in between restricting e-resource discovery to the traditional elements of OPAC records & indexes and migrating selected OPAC content to a separate database to support e-resource discovery.

A list of ERDB subject descriptors, such as the two-tiered one with eight top-level terms seen in one of the draft ERDB search screens David Yamamoto put together, could be hyperlinked for users. A click on any term would launch an OPAC session and perform a search for that descriptor within Taos records. Precedent for embedding Orion2 searches within URLs exists in the hyperlinked DBCNs Andy Kohler has included in the ERDB client.

What we would need to include in an OPAC-search-based URL:

1A. Call numbers are about to become searchable in the OPAC. This brings us the ability to search initial portions of call#s as keywords and to Boolean this search element against other parts of the bibliographic record. However, in searching for "Aerospace Engineering" resources, the equivalent Taos call number search would need to retrieve anything in the range TL500-TL4050; such range searching goes beyond Orion2 abilities.

1B. In lieu of call numbers, we could use the actual descriptors mapped from them. The subject descriptors themselves would be stored in special (9XX?) fields of the catalog records and indexed in a manner that keeps them separate from other SUBJECT-related data, so as not to conflict with other, more precise subject searching in the OPAC.

2. The keyword "http" could soon be available for retrieval when the ACC request to index the 856 field is completed.

Since not all OPAC records with 856 fields are relevant to ERDB searching, the mere presence of the descriptors cited in 1B would give us the needed search restriction.

A very similar strategy could support patron searching by Material Type.

The result of this kind of search would be OPAC records showing links that take patrons to the e-resources.

Workflow support for this plan: To distinguish ERDB resources among other OPAC records containing 856 fields, the keyword "ERDB" could be added (in MARC 653 or DC.Subject) when new resource descriptions are sent to the OPAC from CORC. Those resources flagged in this manner would receive subject descriptor mapping; this step could occur with the FTP load of the record. The keyword "ERDB" is purely a flag for processing the records, and it could be removed once subject descriptors are inserted into the cataloging records.

Implications:

--All records now found in ERDB would definitely have to be in the OPAC, in order to support this searching.

--Future e-resources would need to reach the OPAC quickly, but CORC could help us.

--Trade off could be efficient avoidance of much of the duplicate resolution work now occurring in ERDB.

--Update of ERDB contents could become much more dynamic. We wouldn't need to plan biweekly/monthly refreshes from the cataloging records. As soon as a CORC record hits the OPAC, it would automatically be in ERDB.

--Link checking not currently possible in Taos, would continue to occur "off stage" in Valerie's Access database.